

# *ALPHEN AAN DEN RIJN SEEKS A BALANCE BETWEEN PEACE AND RECREATION*

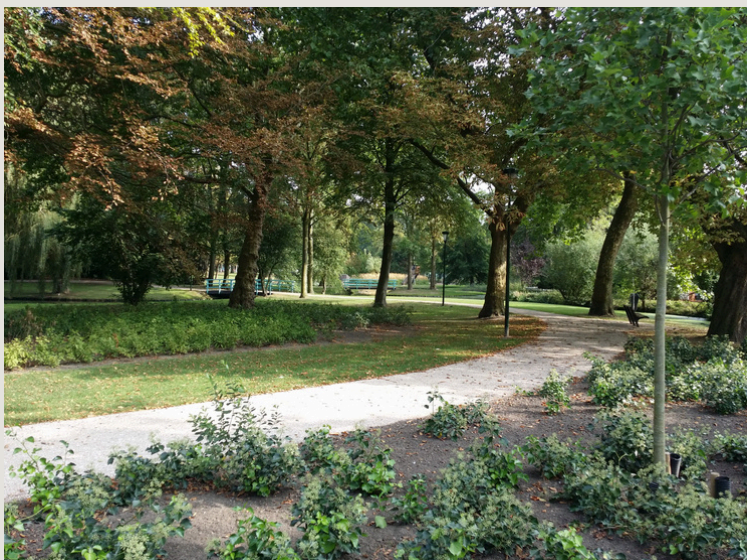
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Parks in Alphen aan den Rijn have improved significantly in recent years. With a wide variety of parks available, there is something for everyone. Each park has its own character: some are more focused on recreation, while others are more focused on nature. Much has changed lately, new parks have been created, and existing ones have been expanded. Residents' opinions vary, though overall they are quite positive. We have listed the most important points for you! Many of the parks feature extensive greenery and support a rich biodiversity. A wide range of trees, plants, and animals can be found in these green oases. Several parks have recently undergone changes, including the complete renovation of the Bospark.

Parking spaces and a large city park area were added, though efforts were made to preserve the original English landscape design during the renovation. The parks of Alphen aan den Rijn contain a variety of trees and plants, which contributes to their rich biodiversity. Park Zegersloot is one example. Thanks to its many different trees, the park is home to around 100 types of birds, something that naturally has a positive impact on the environment. The Weteringpark features both native and exotic trees, including oak, beech, alder, and hazel. In spring, cow parsley blooms abundantly along the river that flows also through the park.



Recreation is another major focus within the parks. They offer opportunities for walks, sports in some areas, and peaceful relaxation. The parks are accessible to everyone, with something to offer for all ages. A good example is the Europapark, a brand-new park with plenty of recreational possibilities, including walking, football, tennis, and skating. The park was fully renovated in 2024/2025, with the renovation taking residents' wishes into account. To learn more about residents' views, we have sent a survey. It turns out that a quarter of the residents never visit a park, which is striking given the wide range of parks available in Alphen aan den Rijn. The number of people who visit a park for nature is roughly equal to the number of people who go for recreation. However, many do not see a park visit as a true outing; they often pass through quickly while walking the dog or cycling to school.



Still, residents see room for improvement: they would like to see more greenery, more places to sit, and additional waste bins. These are all points the municipality could address. At the same time, residents also highlight the positive aspects: parks offer good walking paths and, according to most people, are spacious enough.



# ISTANBUL

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Istanbul, despite its dense population and intensive urban development, is a metropolitan city that still hosts a variety of important urban parks. These green areas offer residents and visitors a chance to escape the fast-paced and stressful city life, providing spaces for relaxation, recreation, and contact with nature. Parks located along the coastline, in historical gardens, and in former grove areas play a key role in preserving Istanbul's natural and cultural landscape. In addition to their visual and recreational value, urban parks help regulate the urban climate, reduce noise pollution, and improve overall air quality.



Urban parks in Istanbul are designed to meet the needs of different age groups and lifestyles. They include walking and cycling paths, open-air sports facilities, picnic areas, children's playgrounds, and quiet zones for rest and reflection. Well-known parks such as Maçka Democracy Park, Gülhane Park, and Yıldız Park serve not only as green spaces but also as social and cultural hubs where people gather for daily activities, exercise, and community events. These parks strengthen social interaction by bringing together individuals from diverse backgrounds in shared public spaces.



In recent years, the importance of sustainability and accessibility in Istanbul's urban parks has become more prominent. Local municipalities are working to expand green areas and improve the quality of existing parks through modern urban planning approaches. The use of smart irrigation systems, environmentally friendly landscaping, and renewable energy solutions supports environmental sustainability. At the same time, inclusive designs such as barrier-free paths, accessible facilities, and safe lighting aim to ensure that everyone can benefit from these parks. In this way, Istanbul's urban parks represent an essential part of the city's vision for a healthier, more livable, and more sustainable urban future.





# *DIFFERENCE BETWEEN ALPHEN AAN DEN RIJN AND ISTANBUL*

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Spaces like Park Zegersloot offer intimate green areas with continuous cycling routes, lakeside picnic spots, natural habitats and safe playgrounds. These parks are used for quiet time in nature, outdoor exercise, or family activities, emphasizing peace, accessibility, and community. Thus, while Istanbul's parks pulse with the energy of a megacity, Alphen's provide a more tranquil, organized landscape designed for slower living and close connection to nature.

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Istanbul and Alphen aan den Rijn offer very different experiences when it comes to urban parks, shaped by their scale, history and lifestyles. In Istanbul, urban parks often function as places to breathe within the city's noise and density, blending large green areas with historic palaces, fountains, museums, and Bosphorus views. They feel vibrant and dynamic, serving millions as spaces for festivals, tea gardens, sports, tourism, and family gatherings, making the park experience not only about nature but also history and architecture. By contrast, parks in Alphen aan den Rijn reflect the calm, planned structure of a smaller Dutch town.

